

Romantic Compatibility and Personality

Executive answer

Assignment contract. Build a science-first dossier for product, research, and messaging teams who need to know which personality dimensions are genuinely useful in romantic contexts, which popular compatibility beliefs are weak or overstated, and what can be said safely in-product without implying deterministic matching. I assume an adult dating context, prioritize peer-reviewed relationship science, and treat categorical “type” systems as secondary unless support is unusually strong.

Executive synthesis. The most defensible pattern is not “find your opposite” or “find your clone.” It is this: people who are **lower in neuroticism** and **higher in agreeableness and conscientiousness** tend to do better in romantic relationships on average, with **extraversion** helping more modestly and **openness** looking mixed or context-dependent. These findings show up most clearly as **actor effects**—what *you* bring to the relationship matters more than whether your trait profile “matches” your partner’s. Partner effects exist, especially for partner agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability, but they are smaller than actor effects. ¹

The common folk model that “compatibility” mainly comes from broad personality matching is too strong. Romantic partners do show **some** similarity on Big Five traits, but those correlations are generally **small**, and far smaller than assortment on values, education, politics, or religion. More importantly, once you model each person’s own traits, **personality similarity usually adds little** to explaining attraction, satisfaction, or stability. Complementarity has some niche support in interpersonal dynamics, but broad “opposites attract” claims are weak, mixed, or unsupported in the trait domain. ²

For product language, the safest move is to shift from “**match destiny**” to “**probabilistic trait-informed guidance**.” Keshner can reasonably say that emotional stability, kindness, and dependability are associated with better relationship outcomes on average, and that early chemistry often depends more on **interaction quality and mutual responsiveness** than on static trait matching. It should not imply that two people are objectively compatible because they share a type, differ on a trait, or fit each other’s stated checklist. ³

Definitions and term resolution

In this dossier, **attraction** means initial romantic interest in first encounters; **conversation ease** means the felt smoothness and mutual flow of interaction; **conflict risk** means the likelihood that ordinary disagreements become destructive; **relationship satisfaction** means ongoing subjective evaluation of the relationship; and **stability** means continuation versus breakup over time.

Actor effects are effects of a person’s own traits on their own outcomes. **Partner effects** are effects of one partner’s traits on the other partner’s outcomes. **Similarity effects** test whether doing better depends on being alike. **Complementarity effects** test whether doing better depends on being different in specific, structured ways, such as one partner being more dominant and the other less dominant. These distinctions

matter because much popular compatibility talk collapses them into a single vague idea of “fit,” while the evidence does not. ⁴

Mode / surface map. The strongest research base here uses **continuous trait models**, especially the Big Five, and increasingly points toward adding broader trait frameworks such as HEXACO. The current review literature does **not** place typological systems at the center of compatibility science. That is one reason this dossier does not default to MBTI-style pairings: the core relationship-science literature is built around continuous traits, and the MBTI literature has longstanding psychometric criticisms that make it a weak foundation for product claims about romantic compatibility. ⁵

Core findings

Which personality traits predict attraction. VERIFIED. In real first meetings, broad personality matching is a poor guide. A 2023 naturalistic speed-dating study using stringent dyadic response-surface analyses found that **neither actual nor perceptual Big Five similarity predicted initial attraction** across 940 dates. Earlier speed-dating work found that **perceived, but not actual, similarity** predicted liking, and even that effect was weaker when measured trait by trait rather than holistically. Another large speed-dating study found that broad traits such as extraversion, neuroticism, agreeableness, and conscientiousness showed **no influence on popularity** in those brief encounters, while an earlier speed-dating paper found the strongest predictor for both sexes was **partner physical attractiveness**, with some support for reciprocity and no support for similarity. The safest summary is that initial attraction depends more on **how the other person is experienced in the interaction** than on whether their trait profile matches yours. ⁶

Which predict conversation ease. VERIFIED with an important caveat. Direct evidence that a specific Big Five pairing creates “easy conversation” is thin. What predicts smoother early interaction more reliably is **coordination inside the interaction itself**. In one study, **language style matching** on first dates predicted mutual romantic matching, with an odds ratio of **3.05**, and it also predicted whether couples were still together three months later, with an odds ratio of **1.95**. In conflict settings, **higher warmth** and less decline in warmth predict better perceived resolution, whereas dominance dynamics are much less reliable as a route to better outcomes. **INFERRED:** if Keshner wants to talk about “conversation ease,” it should frame it as an emergent interaction pattern, not as a static pairwise trait match. ⁷

Which predict conflict risk. VERIFIED. The clearest risk profile is **higher neuroticism / negative emotionality**, combined with **lower agreeableness**, with **lower conscientiousness** adding further strain. A study of 337 couples found that negative emotionality and communal positive emotionality were related to both self- and partner-reported satisfaction, and those links were substantially mediated by **negative relationship interactions**. A large longitudinal actor-partner interdependence mediation study of 2,090 couples found that both partners’ neuroticism predicted cognitive, emotional, and behavioral processes that then predicted both partners’ satisfaction. In observed conflict, lower average warmth and declining warmth forecast worse perceived conflict resolution, while dominance itself is not the dependable culprit that folk complementarity theories sometimes assume. ⁸

Which predict satisfaction and long-term stability. VERIFIED. Across meta-analytic and longitudinal evidence, the strongest and most repeatable finding is that **lower neuroticism** is good news and **higher agreeableness and conscientiousness** are also good news for relationship satisfaction. Extraversion tends to be positive but smaller and less consistent; openness is mixed and sometimes null for satisfaction, with

some recent review work linking high openness more to dissatisfaction or dissolution than to satisfaction. The big structural point is that **actor effects dominate**: in three nationally representative married samples from Australia, the United Kingdom, and Germany, actor effects explained about **6%** of variance in relationship satisfaction, partner effects about **1% to 3%**, and similarity less than **0.5%** after accounting for actor and partner effects. A nine-year longitudinal study likewise found **significant actor effects but no partner effects**, with lower neuroticism and higher conscientiousness predicting long-term satisfaction. Another longitudinal study found that changes in neuroticism tracked parallel changes in marital satisfaction over time. ⁹

Where actor effects dominate and where partner effects still matter. VERIFIED. For established relationships, actor effects are usually the main story. That means the most useful compatibility science often looks like “how emotionally stable, kind, and dependable is each person?” rather than “how perfectly do these two profiles align?” Still, partner effects are not zero. They are often largest for partner **agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability**, which makes intuitive sense: living with a calmer, kinder, more reliable partner does affect your experience. The evidence just says that these partner effects are **smaller than** the effects of your own dispositions and much smaller than popular compatibility narratives often imply. ¹⁰

Where similarity helps and where it does not. VERIFIED. Similarity helps most clearly at the level of **partner selection**, not necessarily at the level of ongoing romantic quality. A large meta-analytic review across 22 traits and a large biobank analysis across 133 traits found widespread positive partner correlations, but the Big Five personality correlations were modest: about **.08** for extraversion, **.11** for neuroticism, **.11** for agreeableness, **.16** for conscientiousness, and **.21** for openness. In the same work, partner similarity was much stronger for things like political and religious values and educational attainment. So the empirically grounded version of “like attracts like” is not “people need the same personality.” It is closer to “people sort somewhat on personality, but sort much more on values, social location, and lifestyle.” Once couples are formed, personality similarity adds little to explaining relationship satisfaction, even when researchers move from broad traits down to narrower facets. ¹¹

Where complementarity helps, if at all. MIXED. Complementarity appears most plausible in a **narrow interpersonal-circumplex sense**, especially “similar in warmth / affiliation, different in dominance / control.” Some older work suggested that such combinations could help. But stronger tests complicate that story: one careful marital-interaction paper found complementarity in affiliation to be a general interaction pattern and control complementarity to vary by context, yet the things actually associated with lower anger and higher relationship quality were **greater affiliation and lower control**, not complementarity itself. More recent conflict work also found that **warmth**, not dominance, was the robust predictor of better conflict resolution. So complementarity is not absent from the literature, but it is too fragile and context-specific to sell as a broad matchmaking law. ¹²

How answers vary by relationship stage. VERIFIED. In **short-term dating / first encounters**, static personality matching is weak; attraction is better explained by enacted impressions, reciprocal liking, and interactional coordination. In **early-stage dating**, what starts to matter is less “Are we the same type?” and more “Do we communicate smoothly enough to keep choosing each other?”—which is why conversational synchrony can predict both matching and short-run stability. In **long-term pair bonding**, broad trait dispositions matter much more, especially emotional stability, kindness, and dependability. That stage shift is important: the science does not support one universal compatibility rule that works equally well at a first date, in month three, and in year seven. ¹³

Contradictions or fault lines

Similarity is highly sensitive to research context. VERIFIED. The literature looks much more pro-similarity in **no-interaction or hypothetical** paradigms than in **live romantic encounters**. A meta-analytic summary discussed in the speed-dating literature found actual similarity effects were large when no interaction had occurred, weaker after short interaction, and tiny or nonsignificant in established relationships, while perceived similarity had a moderate overall link to attraction. But the more recent naturalistic speed-dating study with stronger methods found **no evidence** that either actual or perceptual Big Five similarity predicts attraction. That is a real fault line, and it argues against naïve consumer claims like “you’ll click because your personalities match.” ¹⁴

Ideal-preference matching is not a settled “yes” or “no.” MIXED. Earlier focused work and a review of ideal partner preferences found limited or negligible evidence that people consistently prefer actual partners who uniquely match their idiosyncratic checklists. A later 43-country registered report, however, found **modest but significant** preference-matching effects when analyzed using pattern-based metrics across many traits, although level-by-level effects for specific traits were very small on average. The best reading is not that preferences are meaningless, and not that checklists are destiny. It is that ideal matching may have **some** predictive value under some analyses, but it is too modest and method-sensitive to justify strong product claims. ¹⁵

Complementarity is narrower than popular culture implies. VERIFIED. The literature does not support a blanket rule that opposites are better. At most, there is a constrained and interaction-specific story about complementarity on dominance within a broader frame that still favors warmth, civility, and low hostility. That is why “opposites attract” remains more slogan than science in personality-based romantic compatibility. ¹⁶

Portability notes

The best-supported findings are not fully universal. Much of the strongest evidence comes from **heterosexual, married, or cohabiting** couples, and several key attraction studies use heterosexual speed-dating designs. A recent review explicitly calls for more research on **LGBTQIA+ relationships, consensual non-monogamy, and long-distance** relationships. So the broad trait findings are likely directionally useful across many contexts, but the exact effect sizes and mechanisms should not be assumed identical everywhere. ¹⁷

Method also matters. Actor and partner estimates can shift depending on whether researchers rely on self-reports, partner reports, or both. One paper showed that apparent actor-versus-partner conclusions change materially when shared method variance is controlled, which means simplistic summaries like “only your partner’s personality matters” or “only yours matters” are often artifacts of design. ¹⁸

Open questions / limitations. UNKNOWN. The field still needs better evidence on same-sex couples, non-Western samples beyond the current base, how trait effects interact with app-mediated dating environments, and whether broader models like HEXACO outperform the Big Five for compatibility-relevant outcomes. The review literature itself flags these gaps. ¹⁹

Risks and anti-patterns

The biggest product risk is to confuse **assortment** with **compatibility**. Couples do show similarity on many attributes, but that does not mean similarity is what causes satisfaction or stability. In personality specifically, similarity is usually too small to justify high-confidence compatibility scores once actor and partner main effects are taken into account. ²⁰

A second risk is to overstate **complementarity**. The literature does not justify broad statements such as “introverts should date extraverts” or “a dominant person needs a submissive partner.” When complementarity appears, it is narrow, interactional, and typically overshadowed by simple warmth and low hostility. ²¹

A third risk is to rely on **type-based matchmaking narratives**. The current trait-and-relationships review literature centers continuous traits, not rigid types, and the MBTI literature includes longstanding psychometric criticisms. A system built around deterministic type pairings would therefore be built on a thinner evidence base than one built around gradients of emotional stability, kindness, and dependability. ⁵

A fourth risk is to treat self-reported ideals as if they are the same thing as actual compatibility. The evidence on ideal preference-matching is mixed and modest, not strong enough to turn a user’s stated wishlist into a high-confidence forecast of chemistry or long-term success. ²²

Verification experiments

HEURISTIC experiment one. Compare an **actor-trait guidance** product to a **dyad-match score** product. One version tells users something like “people lower in emotional volatility and higher in kindness/dependability tend to report smoother relationships”; the other gives a single pairwise compatibility score. Track calibration, trust, match acceptance, date continuation, and post-date satisfaction. The scientific rationale is that actor effects typically dominate pairwise similarity effects, so a trait-guidance frame should be more defensible and may be more honest without reducing usefulness. ²³

HEURISTIC experiment two. Run a preregistered model comparison between **static trait features** and **interaction features**. Predict outcomes such as mutual match, second date, and one- to three-month continuation using self/partner trait measures on one side and early conversational coordination features—such as language-style matching, reciprocity, and turn-taking balance—on the other. The hypothesis, based on the first-date literature, is that interaction features will contribute more than trait-pair similarity to early-stage outcomes. ²⁴

HEURISTIC experiment three. Test **similarity**, **complementarity**, and **main-effects** models head-to-head. Build prespecified models for actor traits, partner traits, trait similarity, and narrow dominance/warmth complementarity, then compare out-of-sample performance and subgroup calibration. The expectation from the literature is that actor-plus-partner models will beat broad similarity models, with complementarity adding value only in narrow, behaviorally defined contexts. ²⁵

Bottom-line recommendation

Kesher should present compatibility science as **probabilistic, trait-informed, and interaction-sensitive**. The safest positive message is that people who are more emotionally stable, more agreeable, and more conscientious tend to have better romantic outcomes on average, and that these are mainly qualities each person contributes to the relationship. The safest negative message is that broad personality matching, “opposites attract,” and rigid type-pairing claims are not well supported as universal rules. For early-stage dating, Kesher should give more weight to **mutual responsiveness and conversational coordination** than to static trait matching; for long-term guidance, it can emphasize emotional stability, kindness, and dependability. ²⁶

Safe claims

- People lower in emotional volatility and higher in kindness and dependability tend to report better romantic outcomes on average. ²⁷
- Your own traits usually matter more than whether your personality exactly matches your partner’s. ²⁸
- In first dates, chemistry depends heavily on the interaction itself; static personality matching is a weak guide. ²⁹
- Personality similarity is real but modest, and it is weaker than similarity in values, education, politics, or religion. ³⁰

Risky claims

- “We can identify your most compatible personality match.” This overstates what personality science can do. ³¹
- “Opposites attract” as a general rule. At best, only narrow forms of complementarity have mixed support. ²¹
- “Your ideal checklist predicts who you’ll actually love.” The evidence here is mixed and modest. ³²

Unsupported claims

- Specific MBTI pairings reliably predict romantic satisfaction or longevity better than continuous-trait models. I did not locate high-quality relationship-science evidence strong enough to support that claim, and the MBTI literature itself has longstanding psychometric limitations. ³³
- A single pairwise personality score can validly summarize romantic fit across first attraction, dating progression, conflict quality, and long-term stability. The evidence base points in the opposite direction: different stages are driven by different mechanisms. ¹³

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